

CNRS' CoARA action plan

The [National Centre for Scientific Research](https://www.cnrs.fr/en) (CNRS), a research performing organisation, is a major player in basic research on the global stage and the only one in France that is active in all fields of science. Its unique position as a specialist in multiple fields means that it can bring together different scientific disciplines to shed light on and gain insight into current global challenges, in partnership with public sector, social and economic stakeholders. Together the sciences are used to bring about sustainable progress that benefits the whole of society.

It employs 33,000 persons, among which 28,000 scientists, located in 1,100 research units, and its budget is about 4 billion Euro.

General context about assessment

Assessment of CNRS laboratories (research units) is conducted by an independent national agency, the HCERES. Thus this action plan does not deal with the evaluation of labs.

By decree, the assessment committees for the recruitment and promotion of researchers are autonomous in defining their criteria.
CNRS can only define principles.

CNRS started its reform of researchers' assessment in 2018, long before CoARA was set up.

Getting Started

0.1 Sign the DORA declaration

TimeFrame 0.1 July 2018

Commitment-1

Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.

1.1 Modify the application files templates. Candidates as well as assessors are reminded that the advancement of knowledge is not the only one activity of researchers. Beyond quality of knowledge production, the candidate's guide quotes for example "Ability to supervise research and manage collective projects (national and/or international); Administration and management of research contracts; Valuation of research (contracts, patents, licenses); Mobility, thematic evolution; Participation in the dissemination of knowledge; Participation in university teaching; Ability to lead and animate a team or research axis; Mentoring other researchers; Management of collective structures; Involvement in research administration tasks".

1.2 Communication towards applicants as well as assessors has been thoroughly tuned. As an example, wherever meaningful, the word "publication" has been replaced by "production", opening up the possibility to refer to data sets, source code or whatever."

TimeFrame 1.1 End 2023

TimeFrame 1.2 End 2023

Commitment-2

Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by the responsible use of quantitative indicators.

2.1 Draft evaluation principles:

- a. It is the results themselves that must be evaluated, not the fact that they may have been published in a prestigious journal or other well-known media: assessment committees members must take responsibility for their judgment and not rely on anonymous publisher evaluations or algorithms. This should be reflected in assessment reports.
- b. For each production cited in the evaluation files, a researcher must explain the scope, impact, and individual share of his/her contribution. Providing a full and complete list of productions is unnecessary.
- c. All types of production must be accepted as part of the evaluation: In particular, in all cases where it makes sense, the data underlying the publication and the source code necessary to produce the results must be provided. Pre-prints and other working papers are acceptable production for evaluation. The same applies to “data papers”.
- d. All productions cited in the evaluation files must be accessible in HAL or possibly in another open archive: these are understood to be the actual outputs themselves and not their bibliographic reference. It should not be necessary to provide them in the file, as an active link to the archive may be sufficient.

TimeFrame 2.1 November 2019

Commitment-3

Abandon inappropriate uses of journal- and publication-based metrics in research assessment, in particular, inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.

see Commitment-2

Commitment-4

Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment

N/A

Commitment-5

Commit resources to reforming research assessment as are needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to ensure that organisations allocate the necessary resources.

Action 5.1 Assign a senior staff member to the task and mobilize all relevant actors (HR, PR, IT, assessment administrative body etc.).

TimeFrame 5.1 2018 and ongoing

Commitment-6.1

Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools, and processes. Criteria for units and institutions. With the direct involvement of research organisations and researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and research performing organisations, while promoting interoperability

N/A

Commitment-6.2

Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools, and processes. Criteria for projects and researchers. With the direct involvement of researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and researchers that are adapted to their context of application

Action 6.2.1 As assessment criteria are drafted and published by each of 47 committees, review each and all of them in order to check for any deviation from the principles.

Action 6.2.2 Liaise with committees' presidents in order to have criteria documents corrected.

TimeFrame 6.2.1 Occurs at the beginning of every term of the committees (5 years)

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Commitment-7

Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.

See commitment 1

Commitment-8

Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.

Action 8.1 Engage in CoARA as a member

Action 8.2 Have a CNRS staff member elected at the board of CoARA

Action 8.3 Be proactive in the French Chapter of CoARA

Action 8.4 Engage in CoARA BOOST

Commitment-9

Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments.

N/A

Commitment-10

Evaluate practices, criteria, and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence.

N/A